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Keith Ingham

Pianist Keith Ingham has come a long way since the days he had to sneak jazz recordings into his London home. Born in 1942, he displayed a talent for foreign languages, excelling in French, Italian and Chinese. He augmented his classical piano studies with constant listening to jazz recordings from the States, eventually teaching himself to play jazz piano. Keith accompanied visiting and emigrating American jazz artists, including Benny Carter and Ben Webster, and recorded his first album as a leader with Bud Freeman in 1976. In 1978 he moved to the U.S. and freelanced with Benny Goodman and the World's Greatest Jazz Band, as well as accompanying and arranging for Peggy Lee and Maxine Sullivan. Keith has created memorable albums devoted to the music of Fred Astaire, Billy Strayhorn, Fats Waller and Victor Young. He is a passionate spokesman for American jazz and its leading artists.

Keith was interviewed on September 12, 1997 in Chautauqua, New York by Monk Rowe, Director of the Hamilton College Jazz Archive.

MR: My name is Monk Rowe and we're filming today for the Hamilton College Jazz Archive in Chautauqua, New York. And it's a pleasure to have Keith Ingham here, pianist and arranger, composer, recording artist and English transplant I guess we can say, to the United States.

KI: Yeah.

MR: You have been, I should fill in our potential audience a little bit that we're at a jazz festival and you've kind of been working double time because one of the piano players couldn't get here.

KI: Yeah, Dave Frishberg.

MR: We hope he's all right.

KI: He got sick, sure.

MR: Yeah. But I enjoyed your music today.

KI: Thank you.

MR: Especially stepping in on that last ensemble, it sounded like you belonged there.

KI: Yeah, well that was just a run through, we had no rehearsal. By the seat of your pants.

MR: How often do you get to have a rehearsal in a jazz situation I guess.

KI: Well usually not for this kind of thing, I mean, but those were complicated arrangements so you have to try to get them down as best you can, ninety percent of it, on the first shot, without having played them before.

MR: What brought you into jazz in England? Were you enthralled with it from the beginning?

KI: I always loved the piano, and my parents had a piano in the house but it was kind of beat up thanks to the Luftwaffe, or a flying bomb, one of those V2's that destroyed pretty

much the street opposite, and blew in the windows on my parents' house. I mean this was during the wartime, because I was born in '42, so I mean I don't remember anything about it. But luckily we weren't there at the time. But the piano I always remember was full of glass, you know, broken glass, and it sounded that way. But I used to go to it and play when I was about eight years old, and I always really liked it. But my parents weren't too keen on me playing music as a kind of career, you know, when you really get started. You know jazz at the time when I got interested in it, was like the Beatles or the Stones were for a later generation. It was kind of the thing that parents didn't approve of. And I'll never forget once I brought home a 78 and it was a spiritual. And the title is "DJC Blues" and in brackets it gave the full title, which was "Does Jesus Care" and it was an old spiritual song they were playing. My father took one look at this and he thought wow, this is sacrilegious you know? Can't have this kind of thing. So it kind of was tough. I used to play the piano when they were out and things like that, and listen to my records kind of quietly when I could. They didn't stop me buying records but they didn't approve it.

MR: Was it partly the fact that jazz came from America? Or was it just the music itself?

KI: No, it was like, they thought of jazz, oh well, that's kind of the music of, it was the young people, it was something that they didn't understand, it had nothing to do with America. They didn't know where it came from probably. And yet my mother always liked the popular songs of the day, but popular music then was a pretty, sort of a bland affair. You had people like I remember like Guy Mitchell and Jo Stafford, and these sort of people. There wasn't anything gutsy or anything to offend the ears. Perry Como. It was good, professionally-made stuff, but when the Beatles came over that was a breath of fresh air.

MR: Did the American songwriters of the 30s and 40s, did their songs make it over to England?

KI: Yeah, quite a few of them did. I mean a lot of them made it further than anywhere else on the continent. I mean in France you get songs like "C*es Petit Choses*" which is "These Foolish Things," you know, and I mean they sang them with French lyrics. Quite a lot of the songs found their way over there and were sung, very well sometimes, by Jean Sablon — and in England too, absolutely. I mean very often the British bands would record a cover version of an American hit and things like that. Sure. And then of course during the war when there was a lot of Americans in England as you know, service people and that, I mean they brought their music with them. Of course you had the wonderful Glenn Miller Army Air Force Band came over.

MR: So was your jazz learning mostly from records?

KI: Mostly from records, because we didn't get American musicians coming to England at the time when I was growing up, because there was a musician's union ban I think on

both sides. Certainly the English musician's union didn't want American artists coming in, like jazz musicians, because they said it would take work away from the local musicians. Well in a sense that's probably true, but also, we couldn't get to hear these wonderful people who were still playing. And I bitterly regretted it because they were over in Paris. Quite a lot of them came to Paris. I was too young to get over there on my own. And I never forgot the first time Stan Kenton's orchestra, which was very popular in England, and we had our own wonderful band like Ted Heath for example, a wonderful big band, and Ted's band kind of was a marvelous example of big band music. But Kenton was one of their inspirations. Here comes Stan Kenton. He didn't go to England, he went to the Isle of Man and played in the casino there. And so many people, boatloads of people, went over to hear him. I think it was — I forget the year — it could have been '53, '54 — I don't know, round about then. And you know I was about twelve or something. I mean I wasn't into Kenton, but I thought it was marvelous that finally somebody's getting closer to the shores. Then I think gradually we began to get people coming over. It was like I guess we had a reciprocal thing going on with the musicians. There was a kind of an English — they had this word "trad" — which I always hated — meaning traditional jazz. And these bands used to play what they thought was, you couldn't call it kind of American music, it was very much a European hybrid, with a very loud banjo plunking away, fast and furious tempos that didn't swing, they were just kind of muscle bound in their intensity, and these guys all playing like crazy. But we had a band there, Kenny Ball, which was a little more musical than most of them, and they had a big hit "Midnight in Moscow" and they came over to the States and then we began to get American musicians coming over in exchange. And of course when the Beatles and the Rolling Stones took off, I mean there was — the English pop groups were coming over to America later, in the 60s. Then we got American jazz musicians back in exchange, it was a one-on-one basis, which was good.

MR: I remember, you know Derek Smith?

KI: Yeah.

MR: Derek talked about, he came here during that ban I think and they wouldn't let him join the union.

KI: Oh, right.

MR: And then they finally settled whatever their squabbles were.

KI: It's funny you mention Derek, because I remember listening — there was a program on the BBC, it was a wonderful program, we had some marvelous musicians, you know I'm not talking about these trad people, but people like Kenny Baker and Bruce Turner and George Chisolm and people like that. And Kenny Baker is a wonderful trumpet player. And there was a program on the BBC called "Kenny Baker's Dozen." And this was in the

days of live radio you know, none of this taping and stuff. And it was really live. And these guys were in the studio and Derek used to play piano with them sometimes. And it used to be either Norman Stenfalt, and I'd be listening for the piano player, lying in bed you know, I suppose I'd done my homework and I'm going to school the next morning. "Kenny Baker's Dozen" would come on once a week, some night, round about eleven o'clock. And it was marvelous, introduced by a wonderful broadcasting person called Wilford Thomas, who was an Australian and he had a kind of a nice broadcasting voice you know, it wasn't that usual English plummy, kind of teeth-in-the-back-of-your-throat voice. He was very good. And that's where I heard Derek, and then he came over here. And a lot of great pianists have come over to America. I mean Marian McPartland was probably the first, because she married the trumpet player Jimmy McPartland, who was a GI I guess. And Marian, you could call her a war bride or something. And then of course the wonderful George Shearing came over in '48 I think it was or maybe '46; and then maybe I think he went back and then he came back again. And I think George had the biggest commercial success, I mean without the quintet.

MR: So did you find friends of a like nature who were getting into this music?

KI: Oh absolutely. You know at school we collected 78s at the time. And it was really like a little protest, you know, having Woody Herman records and Tommy Dorsey, Benny Goodman, and all these things, Charlie Christian and stuff. And it was our kind of form of a little bit of, you know, we knew the parents didn't like it.

MR: It was almost just like rock & roll.

KI: Exactly. That's what I'm saying. It was the young people's thing. And I think the same thing was in America too, you know, kids jiving and stuff like that in 1938, except it was, you had the thing here at source. We had to make to do with records, and make do with that. But that was wonderful. And 78s, luckily I lived at the time in a little part of London, south, in Streatham, we had a wonderful jazz record store there. They called it the Swing Shop. And the guy that ran it, Dave Carey, was a discographer, he was a good musician too, and he had a band. But that shop was a bus ride away from my school, and I used to go there after school and spend my pocket money. And Dave, you know, he'd play me these records because he knew I was crazy about this music. And so I got to learn an awful lot, listening to people that I wouldn't have heard of, because you know if you follow the jazz critics, a lot of these critics in England, they had their own favorites. And at the time, it was okay, you had Count Basie, Billie Holiday who were wonderful, Duke Ellington and everything like this. But there was also an area of music that they completely forgot, and that was the kind of the white jazz of the 20s. Well Dave liked that particularly, the wonderful players like Eddie Lang and Bix Beiderbecke, the Dorseys, and Miff Mole. And I got to hear them on records, and I thought my God,

they're fabulous too. These guys were wonderful instrumentalists, but they were also, in the 20s, they were working like crazy. They were running from one recording date to another, running from one radio show to another, because radio was so big then in the 1920s. And that's where I got to hear that kind of side to it too. And I loved that as well. But I remember when the LP came in, that was marvelous, because you had to really save your pennies to buy an LP, and then do you remember the little EPs that came in? Well they were easy, because you could get them in the house without your parents' seeing, you know, those little things you could stick them in your school case or something and they wouldn't see them coming in and of course they didn't break like 78s you know. So that was a boon.

MR: So did you have to stick your ear next to your record player?

KI: I played the records when my parents were out. But I remember the first LP I had, they had these wonderful little ten inch LPs which were marvelous. Billie Holiday and Teddy Wilson I bought, and I just fell in love with that straight away because that had not only the great jazz musicians on them but they had the songs. And I started getting really into these songs there, because you have these songs done in the jazz way by composers like Jerome Kern and Irving Berlin and Rogers and Hart, and you know, all the great songwriters.

MR: So how did you get from that step to the actual playing? Was it through sheet music?

KI: Yeah, and listening to records, mostly through listening to records. I used to try to play along with these Billie records and figure out what the tunes were. I always had a good ear for tunes and I'd try and find the chords around the tune. And it's really — today's world is very different. Because Duke Ellington was so prophetic when he said there will come a day when most jazz players will have to come out of a conservatory. And it's all this training they're getting now, you know, they're going to these jazz classes in these music colleges and so on, and he was right. These guys can play, I mean they have wonderfully schooled techniques. But to me there isn't an original thing amongst it. I mean it all comes out homogenized like cars or cans of soup. Everybody can play these modal things, they're into this. Sadly I think a lot of these colleges, they think that jazz began with Charlie Parker or Coltrane even, and it damn well doesn't. It goes back to innovators far beyond them, who, in my opinion, were a lot more talented, people like Benny Carter, Duke Ellington, Art Tatum, I mean Fats Waller, Fletcher Henderson, Bix Beiderbecke. The list — you should start way back.

MR: Your bandmates today have said the same thing, almost verbatim. And they feel that most of the instructors that are teaching now grew up on Parker and Coltrane, so that's where they feel —

KI: Well it also has a political thing and it has a racial bias too, to be honest, let's face it. They think jazz is black primarily, well I'm not going to argue that I think that the greatest practitioners have been black musicians — no doubt or question about it — but before that, there were also people playing together. And you know, whites and that. Sadly whites had a monopoly on the radio and the recordings and that kind of stuff. There certainly was a racial barrier there. But blacks were recording very much so. Look at all those blues records that were produced in the 20s. I mean so they weren't denied their opportunities. But what I'm saying is that a lot of great black musicians from the 30s, people like Henry "Red" Allen, J.C. Higginbotham, Coleman Hawkins even, I mean they've been swept under the carpet, but they've pretty much been forgotten. People like Frankie Newton, Pete Brown, great innovative players, Chu Berry, Roy Eldridge, Buck Clayton, wonderful trumpet players, who could play rings around Wynton Marsalis. Completely swept under the carpet. I mean they've become forgotten people, simply because these instructors think that bebop is the beginning, the fountainhead of it all. So unless you were a part of that bop thing, you were small potatoes.

MR: You were a moldy fig.

KI: Well I don't know, I mean a musician like Benny Carter, who wonderfully is still alive, there is a consummate genius, I mean not only is he a multi-instrumentalist, great arranger, I remember reading the fact that the BBC in their wisdom back in 1935, they hired Benny Carter to come over and they just formed a kind of BBC dance orchestra, and Benny Carter was asked to come over there and arranged for it. And I talked to some of the old time guys who are still alive who played in that band. They said Benny could play every instrument better than anybody in the band, except maybe the piano or something. But he was a terrific trumpet player, he could play all the reeds, and I think he played a little guitar — an extraordinary talent. No, I mean everything starts, and I'm not detracting from Charlie Parker's genius or anything, but there was a musician of Carter's statute to me is far more, it transcends Charlie Parker, great as he was. But this was all going on ten, fifteen years ahead of Charlie Parker. And Parker comes out of that. Parker grew out of Jay McShann, and he'd heard all that stuff, he liked, I believe he was quoted as saying he loved Jimmy Dorsey's alto saxophone playing because it was so technically brilliant. And Parker was a brilliant technician. But you've just got to acknowledge the fact that there was life before bebop.

MR: Well it's interesting too because those people before Parker, a lot of them, they reached a larger audience than Parker ever did. And it's funny it's not acknowledged, that bebop is technically demanding, and as wonderful as it was, did not have the audience that some of those before had.

KI: I think it had a small audience — well I say small — I mean it certainly took off in a way I think, when you look back on it, but it was the urban areas. I mean first of all there were some big bands of course, like Billy Eckstine's band and Dizzy Gillespie took a big band out. But they were playing charts, and sometimes people didn't hear that thing they could dance to quite so much. But bebop essentially I think was small group things and it was musicians perhaps playing, I'm not saying for themselves, but it was very innovative of course, and I think it was the urban centers like New York maybe and L.A. certainly, those two sort of extremes, and then I think, I wouldn't say it had a big, big audience but certainly there were people playing it all around Detroit and those urban areas where there were jazz clubs and where people heard it. And Charlie Parker would go to those clubs as a guest artist. I think he probably did reach a big audience, I'm sure he did, but I don't think that, there wasn't that kind of commercial possibility to pick up on it. And secondly, most of the things were songs, they didn't have lyrics to them, how are you going to remember a line like "Donna Lee" — it's "Indiana" basically, the song, but you can't sing [scats]. I mean it's the same chord structure but it's the same thing "What Is This Thing Called Love" is that "Hothouse" [scats]. No.

MR: Which one is easier to whistle?

KI: "What Is This Thing Called Love," exactly. That's a good point because something that was commercially possible, people could whistle it, you know, the humblest guy. And it's a very interesting point you say that, because one of the hardest songs probably written is "Blues In The Night." There's a middle strain on it, eight bar, it's a kind of complicated [scats]. Harold Arlen and Johnny Mercer. That was probably one of their biggest hits simply because that catchy opening phrase: "My mommy done told me" [scats/whistles]. You know, going around, here comes the paper boy [whistles]. That's it.

MR: Can you imagine, that would be a great feeling to be a songwriter, and hear people whistling your tune.

KI: Oh yeah, they're really my heroes, the songwriters. I think — I really think that jazz will probably come and go, it's a music of its time, and now I can't see, I mean it's silly to say now, but it's going to go in different directions of course, and I guess people will still be playing and be inspired by it, but it's not the music of today. I mean the music of today I think is Elton John and the things that relate to people now, country & western. I think we're living in a less sophisticated age in terms of music, because the lyrics are very simple, they tell a simple story basically, and that kind of stuff, I mean it's always been there. But there are no songwriters today writing with the sophistication of Cole Porter.

MR: Well they certainly had a different take with romance.

KI: Oh absolutely. Yeah, well there was romance. I mean quote unquote romance you know, or sex, or whatever. I mean it's not out in the open but it was implied. But Cole Porter

was wonderful. Look at how risqué his lyrics could be. "Down in the depths of the ninetieth floor." Do you know that song?

MR: No.

KI: Well it's about this rich lady up in the penthouse in a high rise in Manhattan right? And she's singing about how lonely she is and she says, "even the janitor's wife has got a perfectly good sex life, but here am I all alone on the ninetieth floor." I mean Porter's stuff is very risqué and so was Lorenz Hart and a lot of his lyrics. There were alternate lyrics to "Bewitched, Bothered and Bewildered" that are pretty raunchy. But I mean everything now has to be let it all hang out and that stuff, but I like some element of sophistication in there. I think the things that are not said but implied are much more interesting than just using the same old four letter words all the time, it's pretty boring. Like jazz you know, a four letter word. But I really think that the composers, the American composers are the kind of classical equivalents that this country has produced. I really think that that's the music that's going to last. And however they keep getting interpreted, you know, jazz styles will come and go, pop music styles will come and go, but when you've written a body of work like Irving Berlin, Cole Porter, Richard Rodgers and Lorenz Hart, Harold Arlen, Burton Lane, Jule Styne, Frank Loesser, marvelous songs, marvelous, original, how did they come up with them? Why were they so prolific at a particular time? Because it was demand.

MR: And why did they last so long?

KI: Why did they last long? Because they're good. They're good melodies, they express — maybe the lyrics can be a little silly, maybe some of them are dated — but sometimes they express eternal truths. A lyric like "Smoke Gets In Your Eyes" you know, you're madly in love with somebody and they don't return your love. "When your heart's on fire/smoke gets in your eyes." Beautiful. Otto Harbach wrote that to Kern's wonderful melody. I mean that's kind of still around. And I notice when I'm playing places, young people today they still like that romance, you know, that thing about it. But they'll only ask for things that they've heard, on the radio. And this is where the power of the damn media is really not getting jazz, and particularly the jazz that has gone before, what I call the Golden Age to me is the 30s and the 40s and the 20s, not the bebop era. The people call that a Golden Age now. But I'm thinking about when these wonderful songs were current, currency, when they were part of the language and part of the everyday life of Americans particularly, because they had it first. The young people, they ask for things they've heard. They ask for "As Time Goes By" of course, because of the movie, "Someone to Watch Over Me." And then you play them "Smoke Gets in Your Eyes," oh yeah, that rings a bell, my parents had that record or something, and they like it as soon as they hear it. They like Gershwin, of course I forgot to mention Gershwin, my God.

MR: How can we expect them to get into something that they're not exposed to?

KI: Gradually I think people find things. I mean if you're that caught on with it, you'll hear it.

MR: Well let me get back to — that was wonderful to hear — I want to get back to you started accompanying visiting American jazz musicians?

KI: Yeah. I got lucky. I was so lucky in fact one of my first jobs, well I went to the university, just to please my parents kind of thing, but I wanted to go, you know, it was three good years. I played with university jazz bands there. And when I left it, I was up at Oxford for three years, and I loved it, that was great. But then I thought now I've got to do what I want to do. I've satisfied them, you know they made sacrifices for me to go the university, okay, that was nice. And I said I'm going to try and do music. And they said oh well it's a precarious profession, you won't have a chance, it's just going to be — he'll forget about it and go work in a bank later, or do something. Well I've been working ever since and kind of never been out of a job. And funny enough, my father, within two years had been made redundant from his steady insurance job, and here is he telling me you're going to have a precarious kind of situation, and he was kind of scuffling around to try and find something in his middle 50s. So it was kind of ironic. But anyway, when I left the university, yeah, I started playing with local British bands, with wonderful clarinet player who is sadly now dead, Sandy Brown. And then the Americans started to come over that I was talking about. You know, we're talking about 1964, 5, you know with the start of the British rock thing and the coming over reciprocal arrangements. The first guy, pretty much, that I worked with was Henry "Red" Allen, who was one of the great jazz trumpet players of all time. He'd grown up with the big bands here, Fletcher Henderson, and he'd arrived in New York I guess in about 1927, somewhere around there. And this guy was larger than life. You're talking not only of a great instrumentalist, and a very original player, but he was also a great showman and a great man for the audience. He would stand there with this wonderful brocade jacket and stand there and talk about his life. He was from New Orleans. His father had had a brass band in New Orleans and he grew up, he knew all the old greats — he knew Jelly Roll Morton, played with Jelly Roll Morton, recorded with Jelly. He knew all the people from New Orleans. He knew Louis Armstrong, of course he knew Sidney Bechet, Albert Nicholas, all these great traditionalists. He was part of that heritage. And he'd get up there and he'd talk to them, you know he'd say, "my father, Henry Allen Senior" he'd say, "Louis Armstrong played for him in his band, and Sidney Bechet." And then he says, "I was there," he says, "that was my dad." And he'd create this spell of magic and then he'd start to play. And you never heard such — a chill. And it was the same kind, the French word I think is *frisson* you know, that tremor that goes right through you. I got that when I first heard Louis Armstrong live, and it was the All Stars. And the curtains in the theatre are closed

and suddenly you hear this trumpet playing Louis' signature tune, behind the curtain [scats] "Sleepy Time Down South." And you suddenly realize here is this guy, coming out, and the curtains parted and there he is. But the magic of hearing that trumpet behind the curtains, before. The sound came before the guy. And you see Louis of course. Just incredible. It's magical. And I think those kind of guys had that love of entertaining as well, which I think bebop somehow didn't have. I wouldn't say they were playing down to an audience, but it was not that kind of music. Of course it has warmth, bop has a lot of beauty in it and that. But it doesn't have that kind of charismatic thing that goes to an audience to entertain. And I think the great early jazz musicians, like Ellington, entertainer. Have you ever seen those shorts of Duke Ellington with the band? He's playing the piano, looking at the camera, the hands are going like this, it was a great show. You've seen that drum kit Sonny Greer had out there?

MR: The timps?

KI: The timps, the chimes, what a show — wonderful. And can you imagine Fats Waller, the piano player, you know you've seen him in movies, I mean as soon as he comes on he steals the whole scene, because you can't take your eyes off him. You know he's magnetic people. And I think they had that thing, you know, that quality of, you have an audience, you've got to go and entertain this audience, whether you're playing jazz or anything. And a lot of those guys didn't think of themselves as jazz players, they were just musicians. I think Bechet was like that.

MR: That's what Louis Armstrong said. He said he was an entertainer.

KI: An entertainer, yeah. I think in all humility, it's a really different thing. I think it's the people who've come afterwards have made them these jazz Gods, but Louis, as you say, was an entertainer. He loved his public. Kept going. Like Basie. He kept going right through the end. Duke, the same thing. They had to get that audience.

MR: Well eventually, like Shearing and Marian McPartland, you decided that you wanted to come here?

KI: Yeah, well I was playing with these Americans — and I keep digressing — I was playing with these Americans and they said "come over to the States." Actually it was Red Allen, when he came over there, he wanted to bring me back to America. Now this was what '64 I think. And Red died in '67. And to be honest, I mean I knew a lot of tunes with Red and I thought my God I can't go there. I mean it's like throwing into the deep end you know. And he says, "no, come on, I want you to come and be part of my quartet at the Metropole." Sammy Price, the piano player was leaving. And he says, "you know these tunes and you play good, you'll be fine." So he actually tried, and the musicians union here wouldn't let it happen, wouldn't give me a permanent thing or anything. So I had to wait 'til 1980 before I came over.

MR: All that time?

KI: Yeah. But I did come over to the States, you know the only way you could get over was playing the piano on board a trans-Atlantic liner, and they had some of those left and I got a job on that and came over and that was nice. That's how most of the British guys, the musicians could get over to America and get to New York and hear the music. I remember Bruce Turner, a wonderful sax player who's dead now, he said he came to New York, he got off the ship, went into this little joint on 52nd Street, and he said it was the Charlie Parker Quintet was on with Art Tatum playing intermission piano. And he said the place was empty. Can you imagine? Charlie Parker and somebody else, I think Kenny Dorham or somebody playing there, and Al Haig, and Tatum playing intermission piano, and the joint was empty?

MR: What a story.

KI: Yeah. But anyway I did accompany a lot of American artists, Pee Wee Russell, Charlie Shavers, Benny Carter, oh it was so nice. But of course when you come here it's a different story because this country's so vast. You know you don't see these people anymore, wherever. But when they came to England — anyway, Red Allen was so encouraging. But I got here in 1980 and started working in New York. There were still a few clubs going there and I started beating around and working in places. But I was lucky enough to play with some of the greats of the era that I particularly love, like Vic Dickinson and Doc Cheatham, both now gone. I mean there's very few of those people left, and hardly any of them play, which is so sad. But it's what happens, it's just the way things have to be. But I'm very glad I came here because really America is still the source of this music and you find wonderful things and you can still sense the continuity of what you loved and what still goes on. For example I was playing in a restaurant when I first got here, and up comes a note, could you play this song and that song. And I knew these songs, and they were Richard Rogers' tunes. The guy that sent the note up was Richard Rogers. But at the time he'd lost his voice. He couldn't speak. He had this problem with the throat cancer or something. So he had to write everything down. And on the way out he wrote a note saying thanks so much for playing my tunes. And of course being British, had I known he was there I wouldn't have played the Rogers songs, I'd have thought he's probably sick of hearing that, hearing his own tunes, forget about it. He wanted to hear his own tunes. And they were all like that. And I worked a lot with a wonderful jazz singer, Maxine Sullivan. And I did three albums with Maxine and they were albums devoted to songwriters who were still alive: Burton Lane we did; Harold Arlen we did some songs of the Cotton Club when Harold was still alive; and Jule Styne. And I was so lucky to get to meet these guys, you know. I didn't meet Arlen, but I met Jule Styne and Burton Lane and to actually meet the songwriters and go to their apartment. And I

remember going up to Jule Styne's apartment and he gave us the song that he kind of, one of the last songs that he'd written and he said we could use it on the album. And of course, sure we'd love to if we could do it, and we did it. And up in his apartment there were paintings by George Gershwin on the wall. You know Gershwin was a very accomplished artist. And he had one of Gershwin's paintings. And I remember sitting there and the phone rings, and who's on the other end of the line is Irving Berlin. So I mean you're in there and there's all this thing going on. Irving Berlin, a living legend, talking to Jule Styne who is a legend.

MR: And Gershwin paintings.

KI: And a Gershwin painting on the wall? That's not bad. You think New York is a pretty good place to be. You know I love New York anyway. And I met Burton Lane, you know, the great theater composer. You know this whole tradition of the American musical coming out of theater and then going into the movies and then the songs are taken up by bands you know. It's just a wonderful continuity. And it still lives on in a lesser way. I mean I was playing, and I have a steady gig in New York, I'm lucky to say that because there are so few of them. But I'm playing in this nice little restaurant, and this lady comes in and she said, "do you know a song called 'You Go To My Head?'" It's a beautiful tune. So I said sure, so I played it. She says, "my uncle Fred wrote that." I said, "yeah?" She said yeah there's a guy called J. Fred Coots who wrote "You Go To My Head" of course and "For All We Know" that beautiful old song, and he also wrote "Santa Claus is Coming To Town" which is his big money spinner you know. So she said, yeah, Uncle Fred, I remember Uncle Fred, she said, every time December came 'round, he said, "oh we're going to eat good for the next year" because he got all the royalties on "Santa Claus is Coming to Town."

MR: Thanks ASCAP, for sending those checks.

KI: ASCAP's sending those checks in, yeah. And I remember talking to Burton Lane about that, or talking to his wife actually, and she married Burt Lane and she couldn't figure out how somebody could earn all this money by not going out to work during the day you know. Because all the royalty checks would come in for his songs, like "How About You" and "How Are Things in Glocca Morra," all those things from "Finian's Rainbow," "Ole Devil Moon" — all wonderful songs.

MR: When were you first able to use your arranging skills?

KI: Well I'd done some things mostly with doing things for singers, you know Maxine Sullivan and just arranging stuff behind her. Because with singers it's nice to have a little organized backing like we did tonight, we did those things behind Rebecca [Kilgore], it's lovely. You know it makes all the difference because it gives it a nice little showcase setting for a singer. And I do like singers. A lot of musicians don't like singers, but I like

it because you're hearing the lyrics, and it's good to work, I think there's a very healthy cabaret scene. That's one thing — I mean the jazz scene to me is not particularly, say interesting, it's not, it doesn't interest me much today, I mean what's going on in contemporary ways, which may sound a bit fuddy duddy to you, but I don't believe that anything that's thirty, forty years old is particularly old. Perhaps we Europeans, we have a different time concept. But you know to me Jerome Kern and these melodies are as fresh as when they were first written, and you can still play them with absolute joy. But there is I think a cabaret scene, particularly in New York, where there are a lot of these young people who love this music. They either love the theater aspect of it or they like the cabaret singers, and they're coming up, they're digging into this great archive of American music. And there's so much stuff out there, I mean it's wonderful. I just recently saw on T.V. they did a tribute to Ira Gershwin, the lyricist. And he had found a song he wrote with Harry Warren, "There Is No Music For Me" or I think the title was "There Is No Music For Me." I'd never heard that song. It was unpublished, and it's a beauty, it's an absolute gem. And there's a show in London where they revived it, and that's kind of contemporary. Of course it doesn't get the attention that Andrew Lloyd Webber's blown up nonsense gets you know, because that's the blockbuster stuff, right? That's Broadway now. But it's there. There's a show, funny enough, ironically, what's the most successful show in London right now? It's a show about Al Jolson. Yeah. Jolson of all things. Hopefully people will get sick of these elephantine productions of tuneless tunes. And oh God, I mean the stuff now, like "Jeckyl and Hyde" and stuff you have there, it's just, I can't describe it, it's kind of melody in a way, but you can't really say that this is a song, this isn't a tune, it doesn't have a beginning or end, it just sort of rambles on and rambles in the same basic kind of harmonies that can be understood in Saigon Uzbekistan, simple minded kind of melodies that are picked up anywhere in the world.

MR: Yeah. Unfortunately it seems like the composers have delved into the harmonic schemes of Pop and Rock 'n Roll—

KI: That's right.

MR: Which certainly is not too rich compared to—

KI: No. They're not rich at all. I mean somebody said to me — I often wondered, I said, where did the change set in? He said, "when the amateurs took over the music business, the business side of it." And I think that's probably true. I think it probably came in with rock, whatever you want to say, but it was suddenly the people who began to control the tastes of what's going to make a record and that, were not necessarily professional musicians. Whereas once upon a time, the guys that worked in these music publishing houses, like for example in New York, I mean they had on their staffs — very, very

schooled musicians, who would sort of look at a song and say well is this worthy of our house publishing it?

MR: Like a book publisher.

KI: Like a book, exactly. I mean the famous one, I think it was — who was the publishers of the Cole Porter things? Anyway, famous, one of those companies. And they had a guy called Max Dreyfus who was famous — I mean he was an accomplished pianist, brilliant musician. I mean he could spot a well constructed song. He was Jerome Kern's amanuensis. I mean he was responsible. He brought Gershwin in there, I mean all these people, they really knew quality. But like you say, like book publishing, you had an editor who could actually read you know, somebody who was literate. That's very true. That's a very good analogy. And that's all gone now. What makes a hit now, I don't know. I mean it's just music.

MR: Well I have a very small theory that technology plays a role in this in that the more toys a person has to play with, the less quality you're going to come up with—

KI: Oh that's very true.

MR: —most of the time.

KI: Oh, I think so, yeah, I think that's absolutely true. I mean it's certainly true, about technology, it's certainly true of the CD as compared to the old analog vinyl. I mean it's so interesting now that there are a lot of companies making vinyl again in a big way. Because it sounds better. I mean most musicians will tell you that it sounds better. The old LPs sound better than CDs. There's a reason for it. I mean the analog recording had I think a more natural sound, and I mean CDs sound, it's all very good and it sounds very good, but to me there isn't a heart in it. There's something missing. Perhaps the stuff that's recorded for CD — it's obviously very fine, but when I think about what they did when they transferred the analog stuff into digital and then put it on CD it doesn't sound as good as the LPs. And now they're going back to vinyl. There are companies in America making vinyl. Two hundred milligrams — I don't know what it is — that these things weigh. You know I just bought one the other day. It cost me $26. I got Duke Ellington's "Anatomy For a Murder," the soundtrack. It's on vinyl again. You know I never heard that record first time 'round. I bought this thing, it weighs a ton. I put it on, it's wonderful, on the turntable. Oh, God, yes, it sounds different. You can really have a sense of, almost like you're in the studio. Anyway, that's by the way. You're talking about technology — classical recordings, those wonderful recordings Mercury did, you know, of the Chicago Symphony Orchestra back in the 50s, they had one microphone in the hall and that was it, on a whole symphony orchestra, one mic. They sound fabulous. Because the orchestra balanced itself.

MR: It was up to the musicians and the conductor to do it.

KI: Yeah, to do it, exactly. And nowadays, you go into a studio, if you ever see one of these group things going on, they've got about twenty microphones on a kit of drums. I don't know why. And then when they record these guys, they get these microphones, you know you've got a cello player, and you can hear everything — there's a squeaking on the soundboard. You hear the guitar — you hear the fret, everything is going like this. It's nutty.

MR: Well you've done a lot of research, I can tell because you've recorded albums of Victor Young's songs.

KI: Yeah, there's another great writer.

MR: And Fred Astaire? Is that the music that Fred Astaire was associated with?

KI: Yeah, I mean composers seemed to love Fred Astaire for some reason. I mean he might not be a singer, it's not a singer's voice per se, it's not like Crosby, Sinatra, Perry Como has got a very good voice and everything like that, and Tony Bennett up to a point, but I mean Fred Astaire had a way, I think because he had such a great rhythmic sense, being a dancer, his delivery was very light. And he sang those Berlin songs, you know like "Putting All My Eggs In One Basket." [scats] He had a jazz feel in his singing, as well as in his dancing. And it's beautiful, I mean it's so right, and elegant. And to me he had a jazz feeling. He wasn't a jazz singer. Like what is a jazz singer quote unquote now? Who knows? Certainly not scatting and stuff. I mean but he just had a lovely lightness of touch. And they all seemed to love the way he sang their songs. So yeah, we did an album of his tunes. They're wonderful tunes. They're the — Gershwin wrote "Shall We Dance" and then he sings Irving Berlin, I forget the names of the damn movies now with Ginger Rogers, but it was incredible, in the 30s you know.

MR: I see you were in on a Condon memorial thing too? Eddie Condon?

KI: Yeah. Well that was with Bobby Gordon and we just did a little, it wasn't a tribute or anything. Eddie Condon was a kind of a catalyst for music that's now just completely out of any of these jazz critics or these educators would not mention Eddie Condon. I mean they think he's absolutely beneath them. It's a guy who was a wonderful rhythm guitar player. He didn't play any solos. What did he do? He drank himself crazy and he was just part of the times, but he was a wonderful catalyst. He brought together so many great players. I don't know why — that kind of music was much maligned of course. Once upon a time — it was a particular kind of a New York kind of music I thought, Eddie's music. When he was playing, he had his own club as you know, down in Greenwich Village. In 1946 he opened up I think. And it really kind of attracted a literate crowd, maybe an ivy league kind of crowd down there. They were editors, publishers, journalists, you know kind of somewhat racy and somewhat well educated, you know,

Harvard people and businessmen and that. But they liked it. They liked the sound. A lot of them, like John O'Hara, the novelist, and — he wrote *Cannery Row*.

MR: Steinbeck.

KI: Steinbeck, yeah, the people who went there. I mean Condon's was a great place. Then of course at the time bebop was there, and that was the other side of the fence. These were totally extremes. And even the big bands too, were another extreme. Because the Condon guys thought that if you worked in a big band, you were somewhat selling out, you know, you were sacrificing the jazz for commercial security. But of course there was so much work there, in New York particularly, back in '46, I mean there were so many places going, and there were jobs. So now there's nothing like that at all. I mean it's absolutely all gone. Well the times have gone. But you didn't have to feel, if you couldn't work there you couldn't work somewhere else, or this was the only place to be. And I wish I'd been around in those times, I'll tell you.

MR: Yeah, me too.

KI: Yeah, because also the music had a sense of fun to it. And I like those clubs where people were drinking and talking and romancing and flirting and were quarreling and fighting, and the music's going on and everything is all, it's all part of life. And I think that's why the jazz sounded that way, it had so much color and flare and fervor and if you like, drunken whatever. I love those places, those sleazy bars. It's wonderful. You get just a piano player. People would tell me Willie "The Lion" Smith would be playing in a joint, and there'd be just a few drunks and as somebody says, a couple of ladies at the bar who use more lipstick than deodorant. And Willie'd be playing there and apparently, just to keep atmosphere in the joint, he'd just be vamping [scats] and just looking around. You know, there's hardly anybody in there, but he'd be playing that, just to get something going. And then people would fall in. I think I just got in the tail end of that when I worked in Jimmy Ryan's in New York, and that was that sort of place, you know, you could smell the toilet from the entrance. You know you're up on the bandstand, and they watered down the drinks, and everything. But it was part of the old thing. And I worked there with Max Kaminsky, who was one of my favorite trumpet players, and Roy Eldridge was there during the week, and Max did the weekends. And it was just pretty much the end of that when I got here, '80, '81, '82. And then that whole street, it had another version of Condon's club next to Ryan's, on 54th Street, and then I think the Prudential Insurance Company decided, they bought the whole block and demolished it to make a car park so that went. So corporate America struck again.

MR: Well I'm glad that there seems to be at least a small and loyal market for the kind of music that you're fond of.

KI: Well there is. It's small and I guess it seems to get smaller. If you look at the audience today, most of these people, God bless them, are not in the first bloom of youth. And if only we could reach younger people. I mean the players are pretty young some of them. I mean we're not teenagers, but we still think we've got something to offer. And we sort of work within a tradition and try to do your own thing with it, which I don't see anything wrong in that. And instead of trying to be as modern — modern is such a silly word, because what's modern today gets very dated. And I think if you look back to the things that were considered very innovative at the time, a lot of that Stan Kenton stuff, is dated terribly, and that kind of beboppy, scat singing with the guy [scats]. It sounds so corny. It's like those silly old suits, those zoot suits of theirs that nobody would wear. But the really good stuff stays. And I don't think you should aim to be timeless, but just if you're doing it true to yourself and not going for these sort of effects, and trying to be hip all the time, something will come through. But I do wish, I mean that's where the media could help in a way, but would you ever see a band like ours on David Letterman? No way. Or would you ever see us on even an early morning show? No. It's sadly no. Because these people don't know. These guys that produce these programs don't know. They grew up with The Rolling Stones or probably even like Led Zeppelin and some that came afterwards.

MR: The Rolling Stones are old now.

KI: I know they are. Isn't that sad? Geriatric rockers? Exactly. They're older than we are. They're getting ready for another tour, just to make another zillion millions. Charlie Watts, the drummer with them, I knew him in London. He used to come in and sit in with the band where we played, in the Cafe Des Artiste in the Fulham Road. He was dreadful, but he did love jazz. Charlie's always loved jazz. I think he played once.

MR: Yeah, he did a big band.

KI: Yeah, he loves jazz. He also likes picking up the Charlie Parker thing, and I know he loved Earl Hines and things. I mean God knows he must have felt a fish out of water with those other guys. I don't think Jagger liked jazz at all. I think the only record he ever liked was Ramsey Lewis' "The In Crowd." Do you remember that?

MR: Sure do.

KI: [scats]. Well it had a great beat to it.

MR: The piano was out of tune, too.

KI: Oh wonderful, oh done in that Bohemian Caverns.

MR: It's got that kind of thing you were talking about.

KI: Exactly. That's the atmosphere. Exactly. Can you imagine the bodies and all the sweat when they were done.

MR: Yeah.

KI: It was great. I loved it too. Yeah, you're right. Yeah that's where I like the Horace Silver band, when I was lucky enough to hear Horace in London. I mean that kind of grease and funk to it. I loved Horace Silver. That came out of bebop, but it had that wonderful quality. Blakey too.

MR: Dirty funk.

KI: Yeah, I loved it. I mean I'm not knocking bebop by any means. I mean I don't want to give that impression, because I have so many records in my collection. I just love Horace Silver. His piano playing is so pure. There's not a note that goes to waste. It's like Duke, you know, Duke Ellington. And Monk too, I'm crazy about Thelonious Monk. I mean there's an innovator. I mean God almighty. You have people still trying to catch up with his stuff. It's like Tatum. I mean there's so much to Tatum that it's just impossible to unravel. But when you listen to the harmonic things that he was doing are so extraordinary. I think Art Tatum must have had one of the most brilliant minds in the field. If he could have been in any other field, I mean here is this blind, black guy, who had a mind like a mathematical wizard in a way, I mean how he could find his way through this labyrinth of harmonic sophistication and find his way out of it. It's really amazing. Incredible. He seems to — it's like solving a crossword puzzle and scratching your head and doing everything at the same time, and it all seems to kind of resolve or something, and then — well his critics say he overplayed and everything — well okay, you have to take that with it. It's rather like in a parallel to classical music, it's like those kind of endless romantic pieces, you know like Liszt, I mean there's a zillion notes a minute, because Liszt was that kind of piano player, he was a virtuoso.

MR: I can do it, so I'm going to write it.

KI: Exactly. And very few people could play, aside from Joseph Hoffman and then Rachmaninoff. Because that was a great tradition.

MR: Well, you have to go back to work soon, but I wanted to follow up quickly on one little thing — you mentioned the thing about The Beatles in '64. They certainly changed our society but no one ever said anything about the fact that they opened up a market even for jazz musicians to go over?

KI: Yes they did. I mean it's not only them but all the groups that came afterwards, I mean Gerry and the Pacemakers and all these groups, they came over to America because they had hit records. And we started to get that. And you could send the pop groups over, and we would get American jazz artists in return. So I mean if you could send a group of four, five guys, you could get, in effect — I mean at the time there weren't American groups in a way that would go over there. You didn't have as many. But we had the Stones, Gerry and the Pacemakers, we had Fleetwood Mac, we had Pink Floyd, we had — yeah, Fleetwood Mac are still around, the name, I mean it's extraordinary. They've had a

terrificly long shelf life, I think it's wonderful. But you know we used to get, the musicians would come back. So we'd say good-bye Mick Jagger, hello Ben Webster. Thank God. I'll settle for that. That's fair exchange and no robbery. That's perfect.

MR: That's good.

KI: Well that's how we used to do it. It's how they could work it out. The musicians union, because they had power then, they don't have any now.

MR: No.

KI: No. It's all gone. Most of these people don't belong to the union anymore, I mean these rock people and that. They don't belong.

MR: It's not going to do anything for them.

KI: No it's not going to do anything.

MR: Like they need the money.

KI: I'm not knocking the musician's union, I mean it's good for symphony orchestras, arranging contracts, salaries or whatever. But virtually it's pretty much gone.

MR: I wanted to play one thing for you before you go.

[audio interlude]

KI: "Margie." That's Dan Barrett and that's me. Oh yeah.

MR: This caught my ear because I hear, in the background, he's playing some nice blues.

KI: Oh, I love that. I love those piano players. Yeah I love that music. Gospel music. I'm crazy about it. Oh the music of those churches, the blues thing. Jay McShann.

MR: Nice lick.

KI: Thank you. One of my favorite piano players, Ray Bryant, he used to do that stuff. His sister was a wonderful, I believe, Gospel player, played in church, a pianist. And you ever heard that piano player with Mahalia Jackson? Mildred Falls? You ever seen that Mahalia Jackson "Jazz on a Summer's Day?"

MR: Oh, that, yes.

KI: And when they do that, "Didn't It Rain" that's rocking, I mean that swings like Basie and everything. I mean it's just incredible. It's just I think an organ and a piano, and I think that's about it. And then there's Mahalia's thing. It's just incredible.

MR: Power.

KI: And she's got a tambourine or something. Oh, yeah, it's glorious.

MR: Well this has been a fascinating session. I'm so glad you were able to join us.

KI: Thank you. I worked hard. I've got to go back now—

MR: Well maybe playing will seem easy after this.

KI: I'd like to say a final thing, I also love, have a deep love of New Orleans jazz, you know the old stuff, the Bunk Johnson things, the George Lewis things, they have such heart. And those guys could pick a tempo, that was always right for how they played. That's the

secret I think. I mean that's beautiful too. I really love the whole spectrum of it. Not too much about now, but there is so much wonderful stuff that went there. It's so inspiring because you can draw on that forever.

MR: Are there any counterparts of American musicians who've gone over to England and learned as much about your music as you have about —

KI: What do you mean, the British music? I mean we never had anything as wonderful as jazz. You see, I think it comes from a melting pot society where you've got all these different strains coming together. That's the whole point. You had Italians here, so you have these wonderful lyric qualities; you have Afro-Americans as they're called now, but you have that rhythmic thing they do they brought that looseness and that sense of swing; you had the Germans here so you have the correctness of intonation and things like that. You have that whole melting pot. And they all brought their music. You have the Russians with all that minor key, soul stuff. It's wonderful. Gershwin is Russian but also very Jewish and that kind of sad, soulful feeling that's in his music is, I think more Jewish than Russian or American. I mean "Porgy and Bess" could almost be a Jewish opera rather than a black opera. But it's wonderful. But it's the melting pot that America is that made American music. That's what it is. There's nowhere else, nothing like it. There's nothing like it in the world. You're so lucky, don't lose it, because it's your great contribution to world culture. I mean it's your Beethoven, your Haydn, your Schubert, your Debussy, your Ravel your Elgar, your Henry Purcell or whatever you want to call it. Your Rachmaninoffs, your Stravinskys it's all there. It's Duke Ellington, it's Fats Waller, it's Henry "Red" Allen, it's Bix, it's Eddie Lang, it's Joe Venuti, it's up there. And God bless it.

MR: Oh, God, we've got to get you on Letterman.

KI: Yeah, well okay, well I wouldn't be able to get a word in edgeways because — I'll tell you about the Letterman show, they won't let anybody of any intelligence on there because they feel somebody might upstage him. Which probably wouldn't be that hard.

MR: Well thanks. I feel like we should etch those words in stone somewhere

KI: Well thank you both, thank you Monk, it's been a pleasure. Okay.